

Aynura Erejepbaeva

Prof. Morsi

Sufism as World Literature

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Sufism and the Couplet

This week I spent approximately eight hours on reading and revisiting assigned excerpts and notes. It was quite challenging for me this week to balance what is going on outside of class (or, better say outside the ‘Dartmouth bubble’) with the new Trump administration, and regular commitments I have as a student. I wondered a lot about how much I’ve put into this education, a free yet most precious one, and how brutally it could be destroyed for reasons outside of my control. It is hard to focus on ‘just’ classes when my mind is occasionally wondering about home, family, and my place here. The more I think about how much I’ve sacrificed to be here, the more I think that I should be even more serious about things in class and I shouldn’t slip by any opportunity, because really this liberal arts education at an Ivy League school is invaluable to me.

Since there is an upcoming mid-term exam for my Intro to International Development class, I’ve spent similar hours on it as well. I typically spend such time on reading for a course.

Jalaliddin Rumi was a Persian poet and Islamic scholar, who also multi-linguistically sharpened his pen in Turkish, Arabic, and Greek. His poems enriched poetry about Sufi love for one another, God, spirituality, and was an influential figure for enhancing couplet-based poems. Now I’ve roughly given his background for both western and non-western readers; however, I

believe anyone can read and understand Rumi's poetry without much cultural context and background. It is because what he wrote in the 13th century still feels relevant today. For example, one of his quotes is very famous, and was mentioned in Winnie-the-Pooh, "Always remember you are braver than you believe, stronger than you seem, smarter than you think and twice as beautiful as you'd ever imagined. Yesterday I was clever, so I wanted to change the world. Today I am wise, so I am changing myself."

The Healing of the Sick Slave Girl is quite a humorous approach to Sufi morals. It is his way of explaining that we should detach ourselves from worldly reputation and pleasure for something beyond ourselves toward God. It is a story about a king, who tries to cure a sick slave girl, for whom he has strong love. Story unfolds that the sick girl was in love with the goldsmith from another village as well. The king now is jealous and poisons that person. The sick slave girl slowly sees the king's physical appearance worsening, because he gets sick himself later.

Through sickness he lost all his youthfulness,

Each day his looks got worse, her love grew less,

He soon became so ugly, pale, and old

That she could feel her heart becoming cold –

Love which is based on just a pretty face

Is not true love, it ends in sheer disgrace. (vv. 202-206)

Rumi here urges us to distinguish worldly physical love from true love, which is based on divine love. One does not have to be Muslim to enjoy his poetry, as it reminds us the importance of internal love unaffected by one's physical attraction.

The readings were easy and interesting to me, especially The Healing of the Sick Girl and the World and the Body. I believe it is because I was personally curious about both, and they were beautifully translated into English. I found Self Annihilation and Substance in God quite hard, not because of the language, but because I kept asking myself how one could possibly be 'intoxicated' in God and what it takes to be in that state? Given that most of the Sufi practices have been slowly deteriorating, what has changed about people's way to be fully in love with God?